

RESEARCH PROPOSAL



Client: Kohl's

Researcher: Keegan Smith

BACKGROUND

This research proposal is for Kohl's which is an American department store chain that sells clothing, shoes, accessories, home goods, and beauty products. I've selected this client because I am an avid Kohl's shopper, and I think that many people don't recognize the value and potential of their products.

For this research proposal, I will be exploring how to expand their target audience and attract a more diverse range of customers. According to MRI Simmons Data, Kohl's shoppers are primarily middle-income white women ages 55 and older. Although Kohl's is one of the most successful chain department stores in the United States, it is not as widely used as other stores. According to [Statista](#), 91% of the population is aware of Kohl's. However, only about 31% of the population actively shop there. It is also important to note that Kohl's has seen a [decline in revenue](#) since 2021. Gen Z is [reshaping retail](#) so targeting this group is a great opportunity to gain popularity and create strong brand relationships that will last.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVE

To measure Kohl's brand perception and likelihood of purchase by Gen Z members.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. Why are Gen Z members shopping at Kohl's?
2. Why are Gen Z members NOT shopping at Kohl's?
3. Where do Gen Z members primarily shop?
4. Do Gen Z members believe Kohl's is a good store?
5. What do Gen Z members look for when choosing a brand?

SECONDARY RESEARCH

Kohl's is a well-known and successful department store; however, it is not necessarily popular with the younger demographic. Members of Gen Z are now at a point in life where they are going to college or getting married and having children. These are all big life events that [tend to spark purchases](#) and can sway students to shop at Kohl's. Another thing that Kohl's has already done to attract the Gen Z members is the addition of Sephora to their stores. According to [Interbrand](#) Sephora is ranked 93 out of the Top 100 Brands of 2025 which is something that shoppers may look for when deciding where to shop. Outside of Sephora, Kohl's also sells a variety of top brands such as Nike, Adidas, LEGO, Sony, Nespresso, and many more. Gen Z members tend to shop for their [favorite brands or specific trends](#) so having these brands and items is a great step for Kohl's. In July of 2019, Kohl's also added [Amazon returns](#) to their store which has been helpful for foot traffic in the brick and mortar setting as well as added another perk for their customers. That being said, Gen Z members have turned to [online shopping](#) as their primary shopping method for discounts and convenience, which has made it difficult for stores like Kohl's to get the foot traffic they used to.

Although I was able to find a lot of information regarding Gen Z's shopping habits, there are still some limitations. Most of the information I was able to find was very broad and not specific to what Gen Z members think about Kohl's or other details they look for when shopping. Doing primary research will allow us to get data specific to how customers perceive Kohl's. This can be information such as what items or brands they would like to see or even how Kohl's could promote themselves better.

PRIMARY RESEARCH METHODS

To meet the needs of the research objective, I will be employing exploratory research. This type of research is necessary because it will allow us to generate new ideas and define the exact problems that are stopping Gen Z members from shopping at Kohl's.

I will be collecting both qualitative and quantitative data.

Specifically, I will be using surveys and focus groups. I will be using these methods of primary research because it is the best way to get information specific to Kohl's and how Gen Z members perceive it. Using both surveys and focus groups will allow us to find out the "why's" and the "how's" of Kohl's customers. We can use specific survey questions and scales to answer the question of why Gen Z members are shopping at Kohl's by having customers rate their perception of Kohl's, their experience with the store, and even the quality of the products. The ratings that come from these survey questions can also have great insight as to why Gen Z members are not shopping at Kohl's and whether or not they think it is a good store. Continuing, I would also include questions that allow customers to rank other popular stores and determine where exactly Gen Z members are shopping, if not at Kohl's. Conducting surveys is the best way to find the quantitative data regarding Gen Z's opinions and perception of Kohl's. Once we have gained the quantitative data, I would also advise that we use focus groups with Gen Z members to gain qualitative data and get into more specific details. Focus groups are a great place to ask more of the open-ended questions and allow Gen Z members to share their real feelings rather than just giving a number or clicking a box. These focus groups would lean into where Gen Z members typically shop and allow us to ask why they are shopping at other stores compared to Kohl's. We would also dig more into the last question with what specific things Gen Z shoppers look for when determining what specific brands or stores they choose to shop at. Knowing these details will help us find Gen Z's overall feelings towards Kohl's and what we should look to improve in order to gain more customers of this generation. Using both surveys and focus groups is the best opportunity to gain different types of data and gives you the best overall insights.

RESEARCH PROTOCOL

Sampling Statement

This focus group will include Gen Z members that do not shop at Kohl's. I suggest recruiting 30-40 people and conducting 5 different focus groups, each with 6-8 participants. To find these participants, you should use quota sampling to ensure that you are surveying the exact people we want to target. I would also suggest offering a set amount of money, between \$25-\$50 depending on the budget, either in cash or on a gift card for participants.

Focus Group Moderator Guide

Introduction: [5 min]

Hello everyone, thank you for coming today! We're here to talk about your favorite brands and shopping habits for clothing and home goods. There are no right or wrong answers, but

we want to hear opinions that align with what you all think about clothing or home goods and your current shopping habits. This session is being recorded, so please speak loudly and clearly.

Ice Breaker Activity: [5 min]

Can everyone introduce themselves and tell us where your favorite place to shop is currently?

Focus Group Activity: [10 min]

Everyone is being given a piece of paper and a writing utensil. On the paper, please write in detail what your last in-store shopping experience was like. Include details of what store you were in, what specific things you looked at, anything that you bought or put back and why, and a summary of your overall satisfaction with your shopping experience.

Open-ended Questions [20 min]

- Describe what you think the most important elements of a store or brand are.
- What are your thoughts about loyalty programs?
- Do you care about being able to shop online or in store?

Now that we have a general idea of some of your shopping habits and preferences, we are going to shift into talking about something a little more specific. Since none of you have shopped at Kohl's, we want to know more about why you choose to shop at other stores compared to Kohl's.

- What first comes to your mind when you think about Kohl's?
- Describe a positive or negative experience you've had at Kohl's.
- Do you think Kohl's is environmentally conscious?

Conclusion [5 min]

We would like to thank everyone for participating in this focus group. The information you have provided will be beneficial for us. Are there any questions that have not been discussed that you would like to bring up before we end this session? Thank you again for participating. We really appreciate your time and input!

Research Survey

Sampling Statement

Online shopping	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Free shipping	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
In-store Pickup	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Loyalty programs	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Price matching	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Trendy products	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q4. Please list the top 3 stores/brands that you currently shop at with 1 being your most shopped at.

1.

2.

3.

Q5. Why do you choose these brands?

OE: _____

Q6. How important is it that a brand is environmentally conscious?

1 Not important	2 Somewhat important	3 Neutral	4 Important	5 Very Important
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q7. Do you think Kohl's is environmentally conscious?

- Yes
- No
- Unsure

Demographics

Q1. What region of the United States do you currently live in?

- Midwest (Kansas, Nebraska, South Dakota, North Dakota, Minnesota, Iowa, Missouri, Wisconsin, Illinois, Indiana, Michigan and Ohio)
- Northeast (Maine, New Hampshire, Vermont, Massachusetts, Rhode Island, Connecticut, New York, New Jersey and Pennsylvania)
- West (Montana, Idaho, Wyoming, Nevada, Utah, Colorado, Arizona, New Mexico, Alaska, Washington, Oregon, California, Hawaii)
- South (Delaware, Maryland, D.C., Virginia, West Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, Georgia, Florida, Kentucky, Tennessee, Alabama, Mississippi, Arkansas, Louisiana, Oklahoma and Texas)

Q2. What is your gender?

- Man
- Woman
- Non-binary
- Prefer to self-describe
- Prefer not to say

Q3. What is your age?

OE: _____

INITIAL FINDINGS

For this research, I pretested a survey. The survey was open from December 4th to December 12th and was given to members of Gen Z, specifically a group of students at the University of Nebraska-Lincoln in the College of Journalism and Mass Communications. To find participants, the survey was posted on a class discussion board, and students were asked to take it if they were not current Kohl's customers.

Although there were a limited number of participants, I would say that the pretest of the survey went fairly well. The results we received gave us some insight into the features that Gen Z members prioritize when choosing a store or brand to shop with. We were also able to get an idea of a few of the brands that the participants currently choose and why which will be helpful for future action. One thing that I would change about the survey is not allowing participants that do shop at Kohl's to answer any questions. I think it would be helpful to see why they choose Kohl's compared to other brands or get their opinions on improvements that could be made to encourage other Gen Z members to choose Kohl's as well. I think it would also be helpful to ask more questions regarding Kohl's specifically. Most of the participants were aware of Kohl's and had mid-to-decent perceptions of the

brand. I think digging into this a little more would give us a much better understanding of where Gen Z stands with Kohl's.

Based on the initial findings from the survey, we were unable to really answer why Gen Z members are and are not shopping at Kohl's. However, we were able to determine some of the places where Gen Z members do shop. Finding out where Gen Z members shop now also allows us to find out some of the most important features that Gen Z members look for when choosing a brand. Examples of some of these are affordability, selling specific brands, variety of products, and online shopping options. Lastly, when asked how participants perceived the quality of Kohl's they got an average score of 3.4 out of 5. This means that although Kohl's is not rated as high as it could be, Gen Z members overall don't have a bad perception of Kohls. Overall, Kohl's fulfills many of these requests Gen Z shoppers have when deciding on a brand and has a decent rating with participants so advertising to the right audience could completely change the number of Gen Z shoppers.